Knowledge organiser (TRACK) — Make the identity piece: pattern and portrait

Pathway: TRACK · Week 4 Part 1 · Big question: How can we combine a bold repeating background pattern with a high-contrast central identity subject?

Core studio focus

Family: Identity and studio log

Big question: How can we combine a bold repeating background pattern with a high-contrast central identity subject?

• Follow your Week 3 composition blueprint to map your central subject and patterned ground on heavy A3/A4 card.

• Establish crisp figure-ground separation using tonal contrast, outline weight, or a contrasting halo.

• Combine wet and dry studio media with controlled edges.

Essential vocabulary

• figure-ground: The visual separation between the main subject (figure) and the background space (ground).

• rhythm: A visual beat created by repeating shapes, lines, or colours across a pattern.

• halo: A thin band of contrasting tone around the main subject that makes it pop forward.

• opaque: Solid colour that covers the surface underneath completely.

• translucent: Semi-clear colour wash that lets underlying drawing or wax marks show through.

Three-step studio method

Step 1: Map the central subject and background grid: I lightly sketch my central identity emblem filling two-thirds of the card, then rule a diamond grid behind it.

Step 2: Build the patterned ground with pastel resist and wash: I draw repeating warm amber motifs in the grid and brush a deep indigo wash across the background.

Step 3: Resolve the central subject with bold tone and contour: I shade the central subject with high-contrast tonal gradation and lock the outer edge with a crisp black brush line.